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Received: 18 April 2026 | Accepted: 14 May 2026

DOI: 10.1002/jcpy.70030

INVITED REVIEW

Authenticity as fact or feeling: A dual-process framework of consumer authenticity judgments

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Abstract

Authenticity is highly valued in the marketplace, yet consumers often disagree on what is authentic and even attribute authenticity to "fake" marketplace entities. Although prior research has advanced understanding by identifying multiple types and components of authenticity, it remains loosely connected to broader psychological theory, limiting integration and predictive power. We propose a conceptual framework that shifts the focus from *what* authenticity is to *how* authenticity judgments are formed. Integrating a systematic review of authenticity research with dual-process theories, we position authenticity as the outcome of a *judgment process* that proceeds through two routes: a fact-based route grounded in deliberate, analytical evaluation of claims and a feeling-based route based on intuitive processing, emotional resonance, and automatic associations. This distinction explains paradoxes in authenticity research and generates novel predictions regarding (1) the authenticity cues consumers prioritize under each route and resulting authenticity judgments, (2) the situational and motivational conditions that activate each route, and (3) downstream implications for brands. By embedding authenticity judgments within established psychological theory, we offer a more unified and predictive foundation for authenticity research.

KEYWORDS

authenticity, conceptual framework, consumer behavior, dual-process theory

Few qualities are as universally desired in the marketplace as authenticity. Brands strive to achieve authenticity, influencers seek to be perceived as authentic, and consumers are increasingly drawn to products and experiences that feel "real." Consequently, authenticity has become a defining concern in contemporary marketing (e.g., Brown et al., 2003; Gilmore & Pine, 2007), shaping how brands position themselves and consumer demand. Developments like the rise of artificial intelligence only heighten the craving for authenticity (Jago, 2019). Conversely, being perceived as inauthentic can be a death knell for brands, undermining their credibility and eliciting consumer outrage (Silver et al., 2021).

At its most basic level, authenticity refers to the quality of being real, true, or genuine (Dutton, 2003; Lehman et al., 2019). Despite this seemingly straightforward definition, authenticity presents several persistent puzzles that complicate attempts to predict consumer responses. First, consumers often disagree about the authenticity of the same marketplace entity (e.g., Newman & Smith, 2016a), such as whether a Mexican dish or a country music song is authentic. Second, consumers frequently perceive authenticity in entities that are objectively false, including reality television (Rose & Wood, 2005), fictional characters (Grayson & Martinec, 2004), or even political actors who knowingly misrepresent the truth (Hahl et al., 2018). Third, authenticity can evoke a wide range of connotations beyond its core meaning of "realness," such as heritage (e.g., Napoli et al., 2014), originality (e.g., Nunes et al., 2021), and morality (e.g., Newman et al., 2014).

Accepted by David B. Wooten, Editor; Associate Editor, Chris Janiszewski

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These puzzling deviations from authenticity's definition as "real" or "true" have inspired a rich set of frameworks in consumer behavior research that organizes the many meanings embedded in the construct (e.g., Akbar & Wymer, 2017; Beverland et al., 2008; Carroll & Wheaton, 2009; Grayson & Martinec, 2004; Morhart et al., 2015; Moulard et al., 2021; Napoli et al., 2014; Nunes et al., 2021; Spiggle et al., 2012; Wang, 1999). Although this work has deepened our understanding of authenticity's diverse meanings, multidimensional and often overlapping frameworks focused on defining authenticity continue to proliferate (Newman, 2019). As a result, authenticity research remains somewhat fragmented, with ongoing emphasis on definitions diverting attention from other important questions that hold significant theoretical and managerial implications. Specifically, while prior work often attributes variation in authenticity to differences in the consumption context, it has paid far less attention to the fundamental psychological processes that shape authenticity judgments. Because underlying psychological processes operate across all contexts, understanding their influence may enable more parsimonious predictions about when different authenticity judgments emerge and their marketing implications. Thus, we propose that advancing authenticity research involves shifting attention from *what* authenticity is to *how* authenticity judgments are formed.

To do so, we position authenticity as the outcome of a *judgment process*. This judgment process arises when consumers attempt to determine whether an entity is real, true, or genuine—that is, whether the entity is what it claims or appears to be. Building on dual-process theorizing, which recognizes that judgments tend to result from either more deliberate or more intuitive processing (for a review, see Samson & Voyer, 2012), we propose that authenticity judgments likewise emerge through two distinct processing routes: a *fact-based route* and a *feeling-based route*. In the fact-based route, consumers analytically compare the target entity with information they perceive as indicative of the real or true nature of the entity. In the feeling-based route, consumers rely on intuitive, holistic processing—drawing on emotional resonance, sensory impressions, and rapid associations—to determine the authenticity of the entity. Consequently, variation in authenticity judgments may stem from the relative extent to which consumers rely on what they *deduce* versus what they *feel* to be authentic.

Integrating dual-process theorizing with authenticity judgments offers a new approach to understanding marketplace authenticity by shifting attention away from the multifaceted nature of authenticity itself to the consumer information-processing mechanisms that generate judgments. By focusing on *how* consumers judge authenticity, our framework clarifies *when* authenticity processes activate and how they guide attention to authenticity cues. Specifically, we develop novel, testable predictions regarding (1) the authenticity cues consumers prioritize under the fact-based or feeling-based processing routes and the resulting characteristics of their authenticity judgments, (2) the situational and motivational conditions that activate fact-based or feeling-based judgments of authenticity, and (3) the downstream implications for brands.

Importantly, this integration also situates authenticity research in consumer behavior within well-established psychological theories of information processing and decision making. The fundamental recognition that people tend to engage in either more deliberate or more intuitive processing has synthesized and reconciled conflicting findings across many research areas (Chaiken & Ledgerwood, 2007), including consumer-relevant domains such as persuasion (e.g., Petty & Cacioppo, 1986), decision making (e.g., Kahneman, 2011; Kahneman & Frederick, 2002), and self-control (e.g., Strack & Deutsch, 2004). Yet the complexity found in authenticity judgments of marketplace entities has not been systematically connected to differences in information processing. In part because of its multifaceted and context-dependent nature, authenticity has often been treated as requiring special theoretical treatment and thus siloed from broader psychological theory. Our framework instead repositions authenticity as a judgment process, enabling more theoretical "lumping" rather than "splitting" (Fiske, 2006) and integrating previously fragmented conceptualizations within a broader theoretical context.

This article is organized as follows. We first review existing approaches to conceptualizing authenticity in consumer research. We then introduce a dual-process framework of authenticity judgments, showing how the many meanings identified in prior authenticity research can be understood as emerging from two processing routes: a fact-based route and a feeling-based route. We next develop predictions regarding which cues become salient under each route and how these cues shape authenticity judgments, including degree of epistemic validity and social consensus. We also examine key situational and motivational moderators that may activate reliance on either route when forming authenticity judgments. Finally, we outline the implications of these routes for key brand outcomes, including consumer loyalty, reputational backlash, and innovation flexibility.

WHAT IS AUTHENTICITY?

Authenticity plays a central role in evaluations across many consumption domains, including art (Dutton, 2003; Newman & Bloom, 2012), tourism (Taylor, 2001; Wang, 1999), music (Peterson, 1997), cuisine (Carroll & Wheaton, 2009; Kovács et al., 2014), wine and beer (Beverland, 2006; Beverland et al., 2008), collectables (Newman et al., 2011), entertainment

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(Rifkin et al., 2023; Rose & Wood, 2005), beauty products (Smith et al., 2021), and social media (Valsesia et al., 2016; Valsesia & Diehl, 2022). Perceived authenticity enhances a variety of marketing outcomes, including brand trust (e.g., Hernandez-Fernandez & Lewis, 2019), brand attachment (e.g., Morhart et al., 2015), and product valuation (e.g., Newman & Dhar, 2014).

Despite agreement about its importance, authenticity research in consumer behavior has long struggled to arrive at a shared definition (e.g., Akbar & Wymer, 2017; Newman & Smith, 2016a; Nunes et al., 2021; Reisinger & Steiner, 2006; Södergren, 2021). Although there is consensus that authenticity, in its simplest terms, refers to being real, true, or genuine (e.g., Dutton, 2003; Lehman et al., 2019), this definition does not capture the full range of consumer responses. This limitation arises in part because consumers apply authenticity to many entities—including brands, products, experiences, and people—and across diverse contexts, contributing to conceptual diffusion. Describing a Louis Vuitton bag, Mexican cuisine, a dance performance, or a social media influencer as authentic, for instance, can evoke different associations and meanings. Accordingly, authenticity has been characterized as a "dimension word," whose meaning becomes clear only when the relevant dimension or target is specified (Dutton, 2003).

To address this variation in consumers' ascriptions of authenticity, researchers have organized its various meanings into conceptual frameworks. Below, we review key authenticity frameworks in consumer behavior and in consumer-relevant contexts (see Table 1 for summary).

The typology approach to authenticity

One common approach to conceptualizing authenticity divides it into distinct types. This typology approach emerged across consumer contexts where researchers observed that consumer perceptions of what constitutes authenticity extend beyond traditional interpretations of "real" or "true." Typology frameworks therefore aim to organize this variation.

Early work on consumer perceptions of authenticity in the tourism context assumed the "museum-linkage" definition of authenticity (Wang, 1999), which is concerned with whether an object originates from its purported source or provenance—that is, whether it is an "original" (Trilling, 1972). Under this view, authenticity involves verifying a historical claim (e.g., whether a heritage site, cultural performance, or local tradition reflects its claimed place and time). However, this definition did not capture cases in which consumers perceive authenticity even when historical accuracy is absent, or explain why experiential and emotional aspects of tourism often outweigh strict historical verification.

Addressing these limitations, Wang (1999) proposed three types of authenticity. *Objective authenticity* aligns with the museum-linked view and focuses on verifying the factual origin of an object or cultural artifact. *Constructed authenticity* recognizes that consumers may perceive something as authentic not because it is historically accurate, but because it accords with their preexisting schemas or expectations. For instance, a cultural dance might be seen as authentic even if it is not historically accurate because it fits a consumer's schemas of that culture formed through their own experiences over time. *Existential authenticity*, by contrast, shifts attention from objects to experiences and emphasizes a consumer's internal state of being as the source of authenticity. Here, authenticity concerns feeling "true to oneself," rather than verifying attributes of an external entity. For example, a consumer may travel to a new culture to reconnect with their authentic self, temporarily liberated from the social expectations that constrain their everyday life. Thus, although cultural objects may inform authenticity assessments, the ultimate locus of authenticity in this case resides in the consumer. Together, this typology highlights that authenticity judgments are shaped not only by factual verification but also by consumers' expectations, schemas, feelings, and subjective reactions.

Similarly, Grayson and Martinec (2004) developed a typology after observing that consumers perceive authenticity even in fictional or imaginary tourist contexts (e.g., a Sherlock Holmes exhibition). Drawing on Peirce's semiotic framework, they distinguish between indexical and iconic authenticity, which broadly correspond to the objective and constructed distinctions, respectively. *Indexical authenticity* refers to authenticity verified through factual connections between an entity and its purported origin. *Iconic authenticity* refers to authenticity derived from an object's resemblance to the "real thing" rather than factual linkage—that is, an "authentic reproduction." For example, a document is indexically authentic if it is indeed the original Declaration of Independence, whereas a recreation that closely resembles the original document would be iconically authentic. Thus, indexical authenticity relies on factual verification, whereas iconic authenticity relies on resemblance to the original, often corresponding to consumers' expectations or schemas.

Subsequent frameworks identify similar distinctions in other consumption domains. For example, in their analysis of the Trappist and Abbey beer brands, Beverland et al. (2008) show that consumers attribute authenticity through *pure authenticity* (literal unbroken commitment to tradition and origin), *approximate authenticity* (symbolic or abstract impression of tradition), and *moral authenticity* (perceived genuineness of the producers). The first two types mirror objective

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TABLE 1 Authenticity frameworks in consumer behavior and consumption contexts.

Framework	Approach	Consumption domain	Conceptualization of authenticity
Wang (1999)	Typology	Tourism	*Objective*: "the authenticity of originals" (p. 352) *Constructed*: "the authenticity projected onto toured objects by tourists or tourism producers in terms of their imagery, expectations, preferences, beliefs, powers" (p. 352) *Existential*: "a potential existential state of Being that is to be activated by tourist activities" (p. 352)
Grayson and Martinec (2004)	Typology	Authentic Market Offerings	*Indexical*: "[something that] distinguishes 'the real thing' from its copies… [typically via a factual and spatio-temporal link with something else]" (p. 298) *Iconic*: "something whose physical manifestation resembles something that is indexically authentic… 'an authentic reproduction'" (p. 298)
Beverland et al. (2008)	Typology	Craft Beer Production	*Pure (Literal)*: "unbroken commitments to tradition and place of origin (a continued connection to the place of founding)" (p. 7), focusing on cues that "provide consumer with in situ guarantee of the genuine article" (p. 8) *Approximate*: "symbolic or abstract impression of traditions" (p. 9), focusing on cues that "provide consumer with a feeling that this brand will help achieve self-authentication through connecting with place and time" (p. 8) *Moral*: "brands that [are] genuine in their intent" (p. 12), focusing on cues that "provide consumer with a feeling that this brand will help achieve self-authentication through connecting with personal moral values" (p. 8)
Carroll and Wheaton (2009)	Typology	Restaurant Industry	*Type*: "whether an entity is true to its associated type (or category or genre)" (p. 255) *Moral*: "whether the decisions behind the enactment and operation of an entity reflect sincere choices (i.e., choices true to one's self) rather than socially scripted response" (p. 255) *Craft*: "whether something is made using the appropriate techniques and ingredients" (p. 255) *Idiosyncratic*: "whether there is a commonly recognized (usually historical) quirkiness to the product or place" (p. 255)
Moulard et al. (2021)	Typology	Brand Authenticity	*Overarching Definition*: "Authenticity is a consumer's perception of the extent to which an entity corresponds to a referent." (p. 99) *True-to-Fact*: "a consumer's perception of the extent to which information communicated about an entity corresponds with the actual state of affairs" (p. 100) *True-to-Ideal*: "a consumer's perception of the extent to which an entity's attributes correspond with a socially determined standard" (p. 99) *True-to-Self*: "a consumer's perception of the extent to which an entity's behavior corresponds with its intrinsic motivations as opposed to extrinsic motivations" (p. 103)
Spiggle et al. (2012)	Component	Brand Extension Authenticity	*Overarching Definition*: "We define BEA [Brand Extension Authenticity] as a consumer's sense that a brand extension is a legitimate, culturally consistent extension of the parent brand. In addition, BEA is multifaceted and complex, comprising four interrelated dimensions." (p. 969) *Maintaining Brand Styles and Standards*: The brand exhibits "consistency in their style and aesthetics through uniformity of design and sensory elements, …consistency of brand standards, manifested in production processes, components/ingredients, and other attributes." (p. 969) *Honoring Brand Heritage*: The brand "originate[s] in specific places at specific times with particular methods of production, designs, and styles that reflect cultural associations and concrete referents … [thus] if a brand maintains internal consistency and remains true to itself, it honors its heritage and thus creates connections with its origins." (p.969) *Preserving Brand Essence*. The brand reflects its essence—"the soul of the brand and its fundamental values"… "what it stands for and what makes it unique" (p. 970)—in market offerings. *Avoiding Brand Exploitation*: The brand is not "exploited … in the pursuit of commercial opportunity exhibit inner-directedness and defy external pressures." (p. 970)

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TABLE 1 (Continued)

Framework	Approach	Consumption domain	Conceptualization of authenticity
Napoli et al. (2014)	Component	Brand Authenticity	*Overarching Definition*: "Brand authenticity is defined as a subjective evaluation of genuineness ascribed to a brand by consumers." (p. 1091) *Quality Commitment*: The brand is seen as being held to high quality standards. *Sincerity*: The brand is seen as remaining true to its espoused values or principles. *Heritage*: The brand is seen as having a strong connection to a particular time, culture and/or specific region and/or reinforces and builds on long-held traditions.
Morhart et al. (2015)	Component	Brand Authenticity	*Overarching Definition*: "We define perceived brand authenticity as the extent to which consumers perceive a brand to be faithful toward itself (continuity), true to its consumers (credibility), motivated by caring and responsibility (integrity), and able to support consumers in being true to themselves (symbolism)." (p. 203) *Continuity*: "the brand's timelessness, historicity, and its ability to transcend trends" (p. 202) *Credibility*: "the brand's transparency and honesty toward the consumer, as well as its willingness and ability to fulfill its claims" (p. 202) *Integrity*: "the moral purity and responsibility of the brand (i.e., its adherence to good values and sincere care about the consumer)" (p. 203) *Symbolism*: "a brand's potential to serve as a resource for identity construction by providing self-referential cues representing values, roles, and relationships" (p. 202)
Akbar and Wymer (2017)	Component	Brand Authenticity	*Originality*: "the degree to which a brand is considered unique and devoid of imitation or derivation" (p. 25) *Genuineness*: "the degree to which a brand is perceived to be legitimate and undisguised in its claims" (p. 25)
Nunes et al. (2021)	Component	Consumer Perceptions	*Overarching Definition*: "We define authenticity as it pertains to consumption as … a holistic consumer assessment determined by six component judgments (accuracy, connectedness, integrity, legitimacy, originality, and proficiency) whereby the role of each component can change according to the consumption context." (p. 2) *Accuracy*: "the extent to which a provider is perceived as transparent in how it represents itself and its products and/or services and, thus, reliable in terms of what it conveys to customers" (p. 5) *Connectedness*: "the extent to which a customer feels engaged, familiar with, and sometimes even transformed by a source and/or its offering" (p. 5) *Integrity*: "the extent to which a provider is perceived as being intrinsically motivated, not acting out of its own financial interest, while acting autonomously and consistently over time" (p. 5) *Legitimacy*: "the extent to which a product or service adheres to shared norms, standards, rules, or traditions present in the market" (p. 5) *Originality*: "the extent to which a product or service stands out from mainstream offerings present in the market and does so without unnecessary embellishments" (p. 5) *Proficiency*: "the extent to which a provider is perceived as properly skilled, exhibiting craftsmanship and/or expertise" (p. 5)

and constructed authenticity, while moral authenticity focuses on evaluating the authenticity of the internal states of producers rather than a consumer's own internal state, as emphasized in existential authenticity. Similarly, Carroll and Wheaton (2009) demonstrate that authenticity judgments in restaurants reflect concerns about *type authenticity* (perceived category conformity), *moral authenticity* (perceived sincerity of the producer's choices), and related dimensions of craft and idiosyncratic authenticity.

Most recently, Moulard et al. (2021) propose an entity-referent correspondence model that conceptualizes authenticity as a matching process between an entity and a referent. Depending on the focal referent, authenticity may be *true-to-fact* (the entity corresponds to objective reality), *true-to-ideal* (the entity aligns with socially constructed standards or category prototypes), or *true-to-self* (the entity is seen as driven by its intrinsic motives). This typology broadly parallels earlier distinctions between objective authenticity, constructed authenticity, and authenticity derived from internal states. Although this framework provides greater conceptual integration by emphasizing the matching process that runs throughout the types, it preserves a typological structure in

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which authenticity varies according to the referent used for evaluation.

In sum, despite spanning diverse consumer domains and using varied terms, these frameworks converge on distinct loci of truth underlying authenticity judgments. One type reflects *objective authenticity*, preserving the normative definition of authenticity as factual reality (e.g., objective, indexical, pure, true-to-fact authenticity). Other forms reflect *socially constructed authenticity*, based on shared schemas or category conventions (e.g., constructed, iconic, type, or true-to-ideal authenticity). Finally, some frameworks emphasize *internally focused authenticity*, rooted in personal experiences or perceptions of genuine intentions (e.g., existential, moral, or true-to-self authenticity). Of note, this latter type includes evaluating either an individual's own internal experience (existential authenticity) or the perceived genuineness of an external entity (moral authenticity). In short, these frameworks share a common logic: authenticity judgments vary depending on the type of truth used as the basis for evaluation—ranging from external factual verification to self-referential responses.

The component approach to authenticity

The component approach also seeks to organize variation in authenticity judgments, emerging largely from efforts to better conceptualize and measure brand authenticity. Whereas typology frameworks take a top-down perspective, theoretically distinguishing forms of authenticity based on different sources of truth, component approaches tend to adopt a bottom-up perspective, empirically identifying the attributes consumers most strongly associate with authenticity and incorporating them into a single model. As a result, authenticity is treated as a construct composed of multiple related components whose salience may vary across contexts.

Although Spiggle et al. (2012) indirectly provided an early component-based approach through their investigation of brand extension authenticity (BEA), Napoli et al. (2014) were among the first to systematically organize the various associations linked to brand authenticity into a measurable scale. This effort emerged from the recognition that many disparate factors, including heritage, nostalgia, cultural symbolism, sincerity, craftsmanship, quality commitment, and design consistency, were all associated with brand authenticity. Through scale creation and empirical analyses, they identified three dimensions—quality commitment, sincerity, and heritage—from the wide set of factors that together form the core definitional structure of brand authenticity.

Later frameworks adopted similar strategies for identifying core components of authenticity. Morhart et al. (2015) conceptualize perceived brand authenticity as a global construct consisting of four dimensions—continuity, credibility, integrity, and symbolism—proposing that authenticity emerges from their combined presence. Notably, their framework also links these dimensions to Wang's (1999) typology by associating them with objective, constructed, and existential authenticity cues. Likewise, Akbar and Wymer (2017) identified 40 dimensions discussed in prior research and, through empirical analysis, distilled these to two components: originality and genuineness. Most recent in this approach, Nunes et al. (2021) propose a framework designed to organize the many meanings of authenticity across marketplace contexts. Drawing on interviews, surveys, and prior literature, they conceptualize authenticity as a holistic assessment composed of six components—accuracy, connectedness, integrity, legitimacy, originality, and proficiency—while noting that the relative importance of these components may vary across consumption contexts.

In sum, the component approach preserves authenticity as a single construct while decomposing it into multiple interrelated dimensions. Most frameworks include a component capturing linkage to origin (e.g., heritage or continuity) and another reflecting genuine intentions (e.g., sincerity or integrity). Many also incorporate elements related to consumers' emotional responses (e.g., connectedness or symbolism), and some highlight aesthetic or craftsmanship-related qualities. Yet, perhaps because this approach proceeds from a largely bottom-up examination of the attributes consumers most commonly associate with authenticity, frameworks arrive at somewhat different sets of components (e.g., some include six, others only two).

Summary

Taken together, the typology and component approaches have made significant progress in making sense of the complex aspects of authenticity. Typology approaches have overall taken a more top-down perspective, comprehensively mapping the different sources of truth that may underlie authenticity judgments (i.e., objective, socially constructed, internally focused), whereas component approaches take a more bottom-up perspective, identifying the associations most strongly linked to authenticity perceptions (e.g., heritage, originality, integrity, symbolism).

Although this prior work points to consumption contexts as influencing the variation in authenticity assessments, there has been limited explicit theorizing about how fundamental psychological processes determine when different aspects of authenticity are activated. A process perspective may be particularly useful because such processes operate across all consumption contexts, enabling more parsimonious predictions about when different authenticity judgments arise and their resulting implications

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for brands. One possibility is that differences in consumers' information-processing routes may underlie the wide variation observed in authenticity judgments. Specifically, whether consumers rely more heavily on fact-based or feeling-based processing may shape what they prioritize when evaluating authenticity. In the following section, we detail how authenticity can be understood as emerging from dual-processing reasoning.

AUTHENTICITY AS A DUAL-PROCESS JUDGMENT

We begin from the premise that authenticity is the outcome of a *judgment process*. Authenticity judgments arise when consumers seek to determine whether an entity is real, true, or genuine—that is, an entity is *what it claims or appears to be*. Consequently, such judgments involve evaluating whether an entity's explicit or implicit claims or attributes align with what consumers perceive the entity to be. For example, a bag displaying the Louis Vuitton logo implicitly "claims" to have been manufactured by Louis Vuitton. A consumer perceives the bag as authentic if that claim is judged to be true and inauthentic if it is not. Although entities can make many kinds of claims—about their origin, heritage, quality, or moral values—the core question remains the same: whether the entity is what it purports to be. Accordingly, components such as originality, morality, or quality are not inherently authentic unless the entity claims to be original, moral, or high quality. Instead, these components can be seen as potential claims or attributes whose relevance depends on how consumers process them. This shift raises key questions: What processes shape authenticity judgments? What claims or attributes do these processes lead consumers to attend to? What conditions trigger one process rather than another?

While authenticity judgments may be composed of different types and components as illustrated in the prior section, the processes consumers use to form these judgments likely resemble those used in other evaluative judgments. Dual-process theories have long recognized that individuals tend to approach information processing through two general modes: one more deliberate, cognitive, and conscious and one more intuitive, emotional, and unconscious (e.g., Evans, 2008; Samson & Voyer, 2012). Across consumption domains, scholars have formalized these modalities into models, including the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986) and the Heuristic-Systematic Model (HSM; Chaiken, 1980) in persuasion research; System 1 and System 2 (Kahneman, 2011) and the Experiential-Analytic Model (Epstein, 1994) in judgment and decision making; and the Reflective-Impulsive Model (Strack & Deutsch, 2004) and Hot/Cool System (Metcalfe & Mischel, 1999) in self-regulation. Each distinguishes between a more deliberate route (e.g., central processing in ELM; System 2) and a more intuitive route (e.g., peripheral processing in ELM; System 1). This distinction also aligns with broader work examining when individuals rely more on cognition versus affect in forming judgments (e.g., Greifeneder et al., 2011; Hsee et al., 2015). Although some work in authenticity has highlighted the cognitive and affective components in authenticity judgments (e.g., Cohen & Cohen, 2012; Selwyn, 1996), predominant models in consumer research have not explicitly theorized authenticity as the product of distinct information-processing routes.[1]

This core recognition that judgments are made either more deliberately or intuitively has provided conceptual clarity across these consumption domains. Indeed, a central motivation of dual-process models has been to explain why individuals deviate from normative or rational expectations (Chaiken & Ledgerwood, 2007). In persuasion, reliance on the peripheral route explains why consumers may fail to update their attitudes even when faced with weak persuasive messages, instead gravitating toward superficial cues of credibility or other less relevant signals like a spokesperson's attractiveness (e.g., Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). In judgment and decision making, the heuristic-driven thinking of System 1 helps explain why individuals often depart from what would objectively or economically serve their best interest (e.g., Kahneman, 2011). Dual-process theories also explain failures of self-control, in which consumers choose short-term ease over long-term benefits (e.g., Hofmann et al., 2009).

Extending this logic to authenticity, the extent to which consumers approach authenticity judgments in a more deliberate or intuitive manner may similarly shape the wide variation observed in such judgments. Specifically, we propose consumers process authenticity through two distinct pathways: a fact-based route and a feeling-based route.

Fact-based route

Because authenticity is typically understood to be the quality of being real or true, one natural approach consumers use to make such an evaluation is through deliberate, analytical processing of a target entity's real or true nature. We term this the fact-based route. Paralleling features of central processing in ELM and System 2, this route involves controlled and effortful evaluation. What distinguishes this route from general

[1]Our framework differs from research in psychology on people's lay beliefs about whether intuitive versus deliberative judgments better reflect the "true self" (Chiacchia et al., 2025; Maglio & Reich, 2019; Oktar & Lombrozo, 2022). First, this work focuses solely on intuitions about self-authenticity—whether one's own choices express the true self—whereas we examine authenticity judgments potentially directed toward the self *or* external entities (e.g., brands, products, experiences, or other people). Second, this prior work adopts a metacognitive perspective, assessing lay beliefs about whether deliberate versus intuitive processes are seen as more authentic, whereas we examine how these processing routes themselves shape authenticity perceptions.

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attitude or judgment formation is the specific evaluative task consumers undertake: consumers assess whether the entity aligns with what they believe the entity "really is." This requires comparing the entity's projected claims with the consumer's beliefs about the entity's true nature.

This logic mirrors Moulard et al.'s (2021) entity-reference correspondence model, in which authenticity involves matching an entity to a referent. However, rather than focusing on the referent, we focus on the processing route consumers use to evaluate whether an entity's claims correspond to their conception of the true entity. In the fact-based route, consumers systematically compare purported attributes with information they view as indicative of what that entity truly is. For example, when evaluating whether a Louis Vuitton bag is authentic, a consumer may go beyond the logo and scrutinize verifiable features, such as stitching quality, serial numbers, and place-of-origin markers, to assess whether the bag is what it claims to be. In this way, the fact-based route accords with normative intuitions about what authenticity "should" involve: careful comparison between an entity's claims and presumed objective reality about what the entity actually is.

Although the fact-based route echoes normative definitions found in the typology (e.g., objective, Wang, 1999; true-to-fact, Moulard et al., 2021) and component (e.g., accuracy, Nunes et al., 2021) approaches, it refers to the *process* by which authenticity judgments are formed rather than a type or component. Consequently, it is independent of judgment accuracy: a consumer can scrutinize the objective features of a bag claimed to be a Louis Vuitton and still reach an incorrect conclusion. Moreover, the fact-based route can be applied even when authenticity is not objectively verifiable. For instance, a consumer evaluating whether a politician genuinely cares about voters might examine voting records or policy positions. Although this evaluation involves effortful analysis, the politician's true intentions are not objectively verifiable in the same way as a product's place of origin. Thus, while the fact-based route often aligns with normative notions of authenticity, it is a processing route rather than a property of the judgment itself.

Feeling-based route

Consumers may also approach authenticity judgments through a more intuitive mode, which we term the feeling-based route. Consistent with peripheral processing and System 1, consumers may rely on easily accessible cues or heuristics to assess authenticity. In line with the affective dominance of the experiential system of the Experiential-Analytic Model, they may also prioritize emotional reactions or sensory impressions when judging authenticity. More broadly, this route reflects the "feelings-as-information" framework (Avnet et al., 2012; Pham et al., 2001; Schwarz, 1990; Schwarz & Clore, 1988) and extensive literature showing the role of affect in consumer judgments (for reviews, see Cohen et al., 2007; Pham, 2004).

Notably, the overarching structure of the authenticity judgment remains the same as in the fact-based route: consumers assess whether an entity is what it claims or appears to be. What differs is the process by which they make this assessment. Rather than analytically evaluating claims and attributes, consumers rely more heavily on intuitive, gestalt processing, such as emotional resonance, sensory impressions, and automatic associations, to assess the match between the entity's purported attributes and their conception of what the entity truly is. For instance, when evaluating whether a Louis Vuitton bag is authentic, a consumer using the feeling-based route may rely on the mere presence of the Louis Vuitton logo, on surface-level aesthetic impressions, such as whether the bag resembles other luxury bags they have seen, or on easily accessible contextual cues (e.g., the bag is carried by someone who seems wealthy) to assess authenticity. In short, the consumer relies on what "feels real."

Prior research acknowledges affective and associative elements in authenticity assessments, typically framing them as distinct types or components of authenticity. Indeed, certain types of authenticity (e.g., constructed, iconic, approximate) in existing frameworks note that consumers' preexisting expectations, beliefs, and experiences are influential in shaping these judgments. However, this recognition has not yet been explicitly integrated with broader insights from consumer behavior research showing that evaluations are strongly shaped by schema congruity and consumers' category-based knowledge structures (e.g., Alba & Hutchinson, 1987; Meyers-Levy & Tybout, 1989; Moreau et al., 2001). We propose that rapid, schema-based processing can be understood as a characteristic feature of the feeling-based route, which reflects a processing mechanism underlying authenticity judgments rather than a distinct authenticity type. For example, seeing Japanese chefs and traditional décor (e.g., calligraphy scrolls on the wall) in a Japanese restaurant may enhance processing fluency because these cues match a consumer's schema of "authentic Japanese," leading them to judge the restaurant as authentic, whereas encountering a non-Japanese chef may create disfluency because the cue conflicts with that schema. Consistent with the large body of work in psychology and consumer behavior on how processing fluency positively influences a range of judgments (for a review, see Schwarz et al., 2021), fluency from schema-consistent cues, in turn, can foster perceived authenticity.

Related work on self-perceived authenticity similarly highlights how positive affect can "spill over" to authenticity judgments. This literature notes that perceived self-authenticity often does not track with a person's behavioral consistency but instead reflects a positivity bias (e.g., Fleeson & Wilt, 2010; for a review, see Smith & Du, 2025), whereby individuals feel authentic when they

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have a positive self-view (e.g., Bailey & Iyengar, 2023) or experience positive affect (Lenton et al., 2013). Extending this insight to judgments of external entities suggests that consumers may sometimes conflate positive affect with authenticity, treating favorable feelings or attributes (e.g., high quality) as signals that an entity is authentic. This recognition is also consistent with halo effects, whereby positive attributes of an entity can spill over to shape broader evaluations (e.g., Nisbett & Wilson, 1977). Thus, the feeling-based route suggests that positive affect arising from processing fluency or halo effects may contribute to the sense that an entity "feels real." In short, across both routes, the outcome remains the same: a judgment of perceived realness. The structure of the judgment is also constant: consumers assess whether an entity is what it claims or appears to be. What differs are the features of the process through which that judgment is formed: the fact-based route relies more on controlled, systematic comparison, whereas the feeling-based route relies on intuitive, associative processing. This difference in processing influences which claims or attributes receive attention, thereby shaping the authenticity assessment and resulting brand outcomes.

Importantly, we do not view these routes as mutually exclusive. Dual-process models have varied in whether the two modes are conceptualized as either-or (i.e., ELM), parallel-competitive (i.e., HSM model), or default-interventionist (i.e., System 1 vs. System 2). Consumers may rely primarily on one route, engage in both sequentially, or shift between them depending on various situational and motivational moderators that will be discussed in a later section. For simplicity, we propose that variation in authenticity judgments reflects the degree to which consumers rely on the fact-based or feeling-based route.

In the following sections, we show how this dual-process approach helps address persistent conceptual puzzles in the authenticity literature by anticipating aspects of the types and components identified in prior work. Specifically, we delineate predictions regarding (1) the authenticity cues that become salient under each route and the ways that they shape authenticity judgments; (2) situational and motivational moderators that may activate the routes; and (3) the implications of these routes for brand outcomes (see Figure 1 for conceptual model).

AUTHENTICITY CUES AND AUTHENTICITY JUDGMENTS

Building on this dual-process account, we now examine how the fact-based and feeling-based routes direct attention to different authenticity-relevant cues and shape the resulting authenticity judgment. We first identify dimensions of authenticity cues and derive predictions regarding how each route prioritizes them. We then outline core dimensions of authenticity judgments and propose predictions about how these routes differentially shape those judgments.

Attentional focus on authenticity cues

Authenticity judgments arise when consumers try to determine whether an entity is what it claims or appears to be. To make this assessment, consumers draw on a range of cues whose relevance depends on their processing route. We propose that these cues vary along two dimensions: (1) claim explicitness (i.e., explicit vs. implicit claims) and (2) attribute diagnosticity (i.e., diagnostic vs. superficial attributes).

Claim explicitness (vs. implicitness)

Claims made by an entity (i.e., a brand, product, or individual) can vary in whether they are communicated explicitly or implicitly. By explicit claims we refer to identifiable, concrete assertions made by an entity. For example, a wine brand that claims to be produced in France (i.e., "Made in France") is making a direct, verifiable assertion (i.e., either it was made in France, or it was not). Implicit claims, by contrast, are those not directly stated but implied. Because they are conveyed indirectly (e.g., through imagery or stylistic cues) they are less amenable to objective verification. For instance, a wine brand may evoke associations with France through visual design or symbolic elements without making an explicit claim about its origin.

This distinction parallels the typological differentiation between pure authenticity and approximate authenticity (Beverland et al., 2008) and conceptualizations of brand authenticity that distinguish between more verifiable attributes (e.g., continuity via a literal connection to place over time) and stylistic or symbolic elements (Morhart et al., 2015). However, in our framework, these variations are not treated as types or components of authenticity, but as features of the target entity that may be differentially prioritized depending on the consumer's information-processing route.

We propose that consumers adopting the fact-based route are more likely to focus on explicit claims as they enable systematic comparison with objective, external standards. By contrast, when using the feeling-based route, consumers may place greater emphasis on implicit cues of authenticity. In particular, this route may direct attention to aesthetic and sensory cues as they are generally processed rapidly (e.g., Potter et al., 2014; Thorpe et al., 1996), with processing fluency playing a key role in aesthetic judgments (e.g., Reber et al., 2004). Although some aesthetic or sensory cues can, in principle, be objectively verified, they are often not directly falsifiable. As a result, such cues are more likely to dominate

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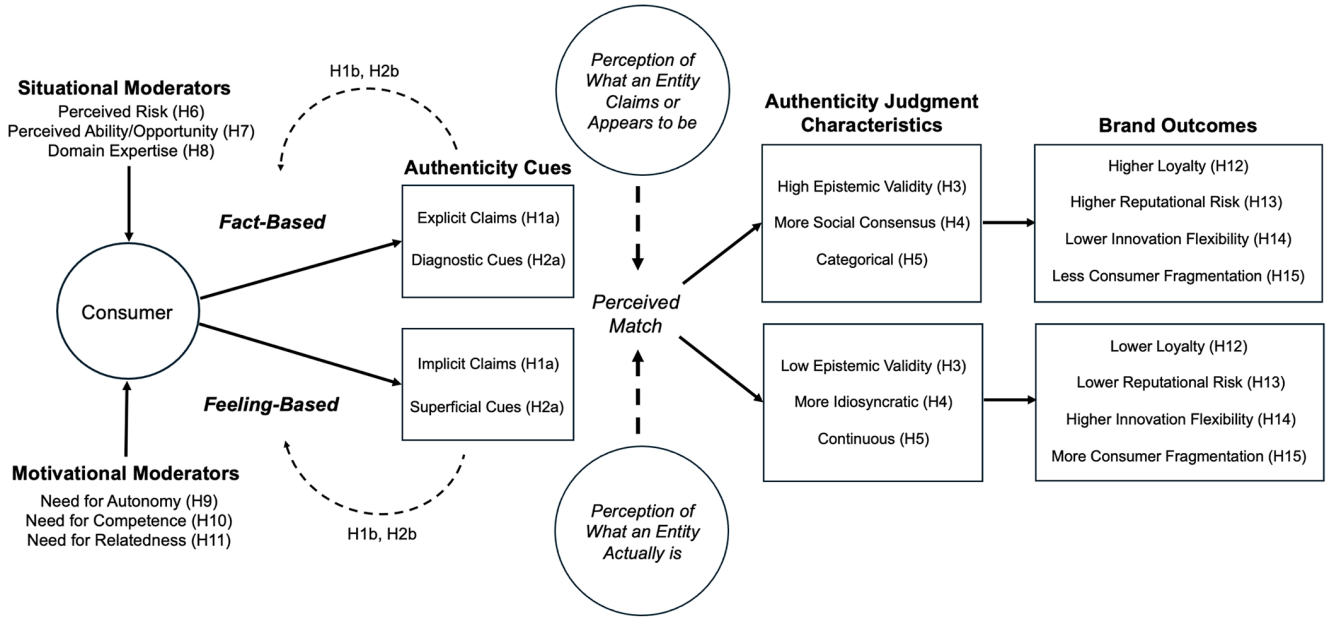


FIGURE 1 Conceptual model.

authenticity judgments under feeling-based processing because they are immediately accessible and require minimal cognitive effort. For example, when evaluating a wine's authenticity, a consumer using the feeling-based route may attend less to explicit claims such as origin or vintage and instead rely on sensory impressions like the aesthetic presentation of the bottle. Thus, we predict:

> **H1a.** When assessing the authenticity of a target entity, consumers engaging in the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will attend more to explicit (vs. implicit) claims.

Attribute diagnosticity (vs. superficiality)

A second key dimension concerns the degree to which an attribute of the entity is diagnostic versus superficial in nature. We propose that diagnostic attributes are difficult to counterfeit and provide more reliable information about whether an entity genuinely possesses the qualities it purports to have. Superficial attributes are readily observable and easier to replicate, even when the underlying authenticity is absent. Echoing signaling theory (e.g., Connelly et al., 2011; Spence, 1973), diagnostic attributes are costly signals that reliably convey underlying authenticity because they are more difficult to mimic, whereas superficial attributes are easier to imitate and thus constitute "cheap talk." For example, when assessing the authenticity of a Victorian era armoire, diagnostic cues would be those that are difficult to counterfeit, such as period-specific joinery techniques or verifiable provenance documentation. Conversely, superficial attributes (e.g., visible scratches, worn surfaces, or patina) are easily fabricated and may merely create the appearance of an authentic antique.

It is worth distinguishing diagnosticity from explicitness. Explicitness refers to the way in which a claim is conveyed (directly stated versus implied), whereas diagnosticity refers to the extent to which an attribute is difficult to fake. A claim or attribute may be explicit yet superficial (e.g., a prominently displayed but easily faked establishment-date sign) or implicit yet diagnostic (e.g., subtle construction details difficult to replicate).

We propose that consumers engaging in a fact-based route are more likely to attend to attributes that are difficult to counterfeit and thus more diagnostic of authenticity. This is because they are more likely to scrutinize discrete cues of authenticity and compare them to perceived verifiable standards. By contrast, because the feeling-based route is characterized by intuitive and rapid processing, consumers relying on this route tend to attend to attributes that are immediately observable and cognitively accessible, likely directing their attention to superficial attributes that are more susceptible to imitation and manipulation. We predict:

> **H2a.** When assessing the authenticity of a target entity, consumers engaging in the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will attend more to diagnostic (vs. superficial) attributes.

Distinguishing between the claim explicitness and diagnosticity of attended cues underscores the broader importance of aesthetics and sensory information in authenticity judgments. To date, there has been limited

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systematic examination of how sensory factors shape authenticity judgments. Indeed, in an increasingly social media–driven marketing environment, authenticity is often conveyed through aesthetics (Maares et al., 2021). This represents a significant opportunity to bridge research on authenticity with work on product aesthetics (e.g., Hoegg et al., 2010; Patrick, 2016) and sensory marketing (for a review, see Krishna, 2012). Our framework suggests that consumers operating through the feeling-based route are especially likely to prioritize aesthetics and sensory information when assessing authenticity.

Moreover, H1a and H2a position attention to claim explicitness and attribute diagnosticity as consequences of the processing route consumers adopt. At the same time, we propose that these cues may also serve as potential triggers or antecedents to the routes. Prior work suggests that brands can influence different forms of information processing based on what information they present and how they present it. For instance, brands can trigger goal-directed versus exploratory search behavior based on the layout of objects in a display (Janiszewski, 1998) or induce more conscious versus preconscious attitude formation based on the placement of information within a consumer's visual field (Janiszewski, 1988). Similarly, the hypotheses above imply that entities may trigger fact-based or feeling-based authenticity processing depending on what information they present and how it is communicated. For instance, a brand that emphasizes explicit, verifiable claims may encourage fact-based processing, whereas one that heavily employs aesthetic or sensory cues may prompt feeling-based processing. Such differences may have downstream implications for consumer responses, including influencing brand loyalty (discussed in the brand outcomes section). Thus, we propose:

> **H1b.** Explicit (vs. implicit) claims encourage consumers to use the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route to assess authenticity.

> **H2b.** Claims relying on diagnostic (vs. superficial) attributes encourage consumers to use the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route to assess authenticity.

Authenticity judgment characteristics

We propose that the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route's focus on claim explicitness (vs. implicitness) and attribute diagnosticity (vs. superficiality) of the entity, in turn, shapes key characteristics of the resulting authenticity judgments of the entity. Below, we identify three higher-order dimensions of authenticity judgments—epistemic validity, social consensus, and structural form—and make predictions about how they are shaped by these proposed routes.

Epistemic validity

One core feature of an authenticity judgment is its epistemic validity, which refers to the extent to which a judgment corresponds to objective reality—in essence, its accuracy. For instance, if a consumer judges a Louis Vuitton bag to be authentic and it is in fact authentic, the judgment has high epistemic validity; if the bag is inauthentic, the judgment has low epistemic validity. Consistent with typologies recognizing that types of authenticity align with objective reality (e.g., Moulard et al., 2021; Wang, 1999) or component approaches highlighting accuracy (Nunes et al., 2021), authenticity judgments can be assessed based on the extent to which they accord with verifiable facts outside of the consumer. However, we do not conceptualize epistemic validity as a distinct type or component of authenticity. Rather, we argue that all authenticity judgments are perceptions of realness, but these perceptions may systematically vary in epistemic validity depending on the processing route through which they are formed.

We propose that judgments formed via the fact-based route are more likely to be higher in epistemic validity. Consistent with H1a and H2a, this is because consumers are more likely to attend to explicit claims or diagnostic attributes that tend to be more consistent with objectively verifiable criteria. Although such processing does not guarantee accuracy, it increases the likelihood that authenticity judgments align with externally confirmable evidence. By contrast, judgments formed via the feeling-based route rely on implicit claims (H1a) and superficial attributes (H2a), which are more closely tied to affective reactions, sensory impressions, and intuitive associations. These processes tend to be less tied to verifiable evidence and therefore less consistently reflect objective reality.

However, we do not suggest that intuitive judgments are inherently inaccurate. Research on thin-slicing shows that individuals can form surprisingly accurate assessments from minimal information (Ambady & Rosenthal, 1992; Willis & Todorov, 2006). Further, reliance on feelings can be adaptive or "logical" (Pham, 2004). From an evolutionary perspective, rapid affective assessments may be well-calibrated for interpersonal contexts, particularly when individuals infer social or relational qualities (e.g., sincerity) from perceived authenticity. In this sense, authenticity can have a "know-it-when-you-see-it" quality, suggesting that consumers may sometimes accurately recognize (in)authenticity through immediate intuitive impressions rather than deliberate analysis. Nevertheless, because such judgments are not systematically anchored in verifiable evidence, their epistemic validity is likely to vary more widely than judgments derived from the fact-based route. Taken together, we posit:

> **H3.** Authenticity judgments formed via the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will exhibit greater epistemic validity.

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Social consensus

Another key dimension of authenticity judgments is the degree of social consensus—the extent to which consumers agree that a target entity is authentic. Although related to epistemic validity, the two are distinct: epistemic validity concerns whether a judgment is objectively true, whereas social consensus reflects the degree of intersubjective agreement regarding shared meanings or standards (Wan et al., 2010). Thus, authenticity judgments may vary not only in accuracy but also in how widely they are shared.

Prior work implicitly treats social consensus as central to certain types of authenticity. Constructed, type, and true-to-ideal authenticity all suggest that authenticity depends on alignment with category membership or societally shared standards (e.g., Carroll & Wheaton, 2009; Moulard et al., 2021; Wang, 1999). For instance, whether a Mexican dish is authentic depends on socially shared standards rather than on fixed truth. We conceptualize social consensus as a cross-cutting dimension of authenticity judgments that varies systematically with consumers' processing routes. Anticipating consensus is particularly valuable for marketers seeking to predict broad consumer reactions, as we discuss in the brand outcomes section.

We propose that authenticity judgments formed via the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route are more likely to possess greater social consensus. When engaging in fact-based processing, consumers rely on explicit claims that often have externally verifiable standards (H1a). Because these standards are often shared and perceived as objective, they reduce interpretive variability, increasing the likelihood that authenticity judgments converge across consumers. For example, consumers may evaluate the authenticity of Mexican cuisine using commonly accepted indicators of authenticity, such as a dish's historical continuity or ingredients sourced from the country of origin. By contrast, feeling-based processing relies on the emotional reactions, sensory impressions, and personal associations elicited by implicit claims (H1a) or superficial attributes (H2a). Cues like the music playing in the restaurant or the weathered look of the menu may evoke impressions of Mexican tradition, leading to inferences of authenticity. Because these reactions are more likely to vary across individuals, authenticity judgments formed through this route are less likely to lead to intersubjective agreement. That said, feeling-based processing can sometimes produce social consensus: when consumers share similar schemas or cultural experiences, affective responses may indeed align. However, because such consensus depends on subjective experience rather than on more stable, externally anchored standards, it is less consistently achieved. Taken together, we posit:

> **H4.** Authenticity judgments formed via the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will exhibit greater social consensus.

Structural form

Another dimension of authenticity judgments is structural form—the degree to which authenticity judgments are categorical (i.e., binary in nature) versus continuous. Although this dimension has yet to be clearly delineated as a feature of authenticity judgments, we propose that it is meaningful as it helps predict when consumers will accept deviations in authenticity. As we detail in the brand outcomes section, binary judgments likely lead to harsher negative reactions from consumers, because they draw a clearer line between authentic and inauthentic, whereas continuous judgments may allow for greater tolerance of deviations.

We reason that authenticity judgments stemming from the fact-based route are more likely to be categorical. Because this route directs attention to explicit, falsifiable claims (H1a), entities are more likely to be evaluated as either meeting or failing to meet objective criteria. For example, a consumer may categorize Converse's Chuck Taylor All Star shoes as inauthentic after any change to the 100-year-old shoe design because the objective link between the design and its origin has been broken. This all-or-nothing structure parallels prior work on purity and categorical evaluation (Newman, 2016), in which violations undermine authenticity entirely rather than incrementally. By contrast, consumers engaging in the feeling-based route may perceive authenticity along a gradient, with entities feeling more or less authentic depending on the strength and coherence of affective or sensory impressions. Because this route emphasizes implicit, less falsifiable claims (H1a), authenticity is experienced more as a matter of degree. For instance, a consumer may judge updated Chuck Taylor All Star shoes as *somewhat* authentic because the overall style and feel of the shoe are relatively similar to original. We predict:

> **H5.** Authenticity judgments formed via the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will be more categorical (vs. continuous) in structural form.

In sum, we propose that consumers relying on the fact-based route will be more likely to attend to explicit claims of the entity (H1a) and diagnostic cues (H2a). As a result, authenticity judgments exhibit higher epistemic validity (H3), social consensus (H4), and a more binary structure (H5). By contrast, the feeling-based route leads consumers to focus on implicit claims of the entity (H1a) and superficial cues (H2a). Consequently, authenticity judgments exhibit lower epistemic validity (H3), greater idiosyncrasy (H4), and a more continuous structure (H5). We have also proposed that claim explicitness (H1b) and attribute diagnosticity (H2b) may serve as antecedents that activate alternative processing routes. The next section examines situational and motivational moderators that may induce reliance on these routes.

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SITUATIONAL AND MOTIVATIONAL MODERATORS

Relatively little systematic work has examined the situational and motivational moderators that shape when and how consumers assess authenticity. This gap is perhaps largely due to the construct of authenticity itself, which has required substantial conceptual unpacking. By focusing on fundamental psychological processes underlying authenticity judgments, our framework helps identify moderators that may trigger different processing routes.

Situational moderators

We begin with situational moderators that emerge from the recognition that consumers can approach authenticity judgments through fact-based or feeling-based processing: perceived risk, perceived ability or opportunity, and domain expertise.

Perceived risk

An underexplored facet of authenticity judgments is that they do not carry equal stakes. Some entail meaningful financial, physical, or social consequences if they are inaccurate (H3), whereas others are relatively inconsequential. In keeping with foundational work showing that processing routes depend on personal relevance (e.g., Petty et al., 1981, 1983), we propose that the perceived risk associated with an authenticity judgment shapes the processing route consumers employ. When the stakes are high, consumers are more likely to engage in effortful verification and hence use the fact-based route. When the stakes are low, they can afford to rely on less effortful, feeling-based processing. For example, a consumer considering a $25,000 painting is likely to rely on the fact-based route to verify that the painting is genuinely produced by the purported artist, given the high cost of being incorrect. By contrast, a consumer spending $10 on a meal at a restaurant believed to be an authentic hole-in-the-wall Chinese spot faces minimal consequences if mistaken and may rely on aesthetic cues and overall "vibes" to judge authenticity. We posit:

> **H6.** When an authenticity assessment involves high (vs. low) perceived risk, consumers are more likely to rely on the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route in forming their authenticity judgments.

Perceived ability or opportunity

Consumers can vary in whether they perceive that they have the ability or opportunity (i.e., cognitive resources and the available time) to consider the authenticity of a marketplace entity. Research in the ELM and the MAO framework (motivation, ability, opportunity) demonstrates that ability and opportunity reliably shape the depth of information processing (MacInnis & Jaworski, 1989; MacInnis et al., 1991; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986; Shiv & Fedorikhin, 1999). Although dual-process theories widely recognize MAO factors as drivers of processing depth, these antecedents have not been applied to authenticity judgments. Consistent with this perspective, we propose that ability and opportunity influence the processing route consumers employ when evaluating authenticity claims. When consumers have sufficient cognitive resources and time, they are better able to engage in fact-based processing. By contrast, when time is perceived to be constrained or cognitive load is high, consumers are more likely to rely on intuitive impressions and surface cues. For example, a parent shopping under time pressure may rely on packaging cues or general "healthy" aesthetics (H1a, H2a) to judge whether a product is authentically organic. A consumer with ample time may examine ingredient lists, certifications, and company practices to verify organic authenticity claims. We propose:

> **H7.** When consumers have high (vs. low) perceived ability or opportunity to consider authenticity, they are more likely to rely on the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route in forming their authenticity judgments.

Domain expertise

Domain expertise likely shapes how consumers assess authenticity. Expertise is typically acquired through deliberate practice (Ericsson et al., 1993), reflecting fact-based processing. As consumers develop expertise, they engage in careful study of the attributes that distinguish authentic from inauthentic entities (H2a). For example, art experts gain detailed knowledge through extensive analysis of artworks. Through this training, experts come to appreciate the value of assessing authenticity via a fact-based route. That said, there may be scenarios in which experts appropriately rely on feeling-based processing, as their intuitive judgments reflect well-calibrated schemas developed through prior exposure (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987). An art expert who has viewed many authentic Picassos may know when authenticity can be accurately assessed from quick impressions. Importantly, expertise also enables recognition of when observable cues are insufficient and deeper, fact-based assessment is required, as it improves the calibration of domain knowledge (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987, 2000). Thus, while domain expertise may lead to more accurate intuitive judgments, these judgments are honed through fact-based processing. Taken together, consumers with

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greater domain expertise will be more likely to rely on fact-based (vs. feeling-based) processing when assessing authenticity.

> **H8.** When consumers have high (vs. low) domain expertise, they are more likely to rely on the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route in forming their authenticity judgments.

Motivational moderators

Relatively little work has examined how consumer motivations predict the desire for authenticity or the form it takes. Beverland and Farrelly (2010), drawing on qualitative analysis of consumer interviews, identified three motivations for authenticity: control, connection, and virtue. Newman and Smith (2016b) empirically demonstrated how the need to belong predicts desire for certain authentic products. Building on this work, we theorize how the fact-based and feeling-based routes accord with self-determination theory (SDT), a prominent theory of human motivation closely linked to authenticity (e.g., Kernis & Goldman, 2006; Ryan & Deci, 2000). Self-determination theory proposes three core motivations—autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Deci & Ryan, 1985; Ryan & Deci, 2020)—which we propose shape consumer reliance on fact-based versus feeling-based processing when evaluating authenticity.

Need for autonomy

Need for autonomy refers to the need to feel that one's actions are self-driven and not due to external pressure (Niemiec & Ryan, 2009; Ryan & Deci, 2020). We propose that this need can shape whether consumers rely on fact-based or feeling-based processing. Specifically, a high need for autonomy heightens sensitivity to internal states, increasing reliance on internal experiential cues when assessing authenticity. In other words, a high need for autonomy may increase people's tendency to lean on *themselves* as the determinant of authenticity. For example, when engaged in a tourist experience, consumers high in autonomy may focus on how the experience makes them feel to determine whether it is authentic. The feeling-based route may also appeal to those who desire autonomy because it may result in an authenticity judgment that feels more unique or idiosyncratic to them rather than conforming to others' assessments (H4). Conversely, consumers with a low need for autonomy may rely more heavily on external markers to determine authenticity, consistent with the fact-based route.

> **H9.** Consumers with a high (vs. low) need for autonomy will be more likely to employ the feeling-based (vs. fact-based) route when assessing authenticity.

Need for competence

Need for competence refers to the need to feel that one's actions are effective and capable of producing desired outcomes (Niemiec & Ryan, 2009; Ryan & Deci, 2020). While autonomy heightens attention to internal experiential states, competence emphasizes effectiveness, performance, and externally verifiable success. Individuals with a high need for competence are motivated to confirm that their actions and choices are objectively valid and efficacious. Thus, they may be more likely to engage in the fact-based route, relying on external markers that can be objectively verified when determining whether something is authentic (H1a, H2a) to arrive at a more accurate assessment (H3). For example, in a tourist context, consumers with a high need for competence may evaluate authenticity based on whether the experience corresponds with historically accurate features, which is consistent with the fact-based route. However, consumers with a low need for competence may place relatively less weight on such factors. Thus:

> **H10.** Consumers with a high (vs. low) need for competence will be more likely to employ a fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route when assessing authenticity.

Need for relatedness

Need for relatedness, or the desire to feel connected to others (Niemiec & Ryan, 2009; Ryan & Deci, 2020), may shape how consumers form authenticity judgments. Because fact-based processing tends to lead to assessments that exhibit higher social consensus (H4), consumers seeking relatedness may rely on this route to enhance intersubjective agreement. Supporting this view, consumers with a high need to belong respond more positively to diagnostic, falsifiable cues that signal a direct link between a product and a valued individual (Newman & Smith 2016b), implying greater reliance on fact-based processing (H2a). However, a need for relatedness could move a consumer toward feeling-based processing when doing so would create greater social connection. For instance, the need to belong can lead consumers to emphasize their experiential states in pursuit of authentic connection (Beverland & Farrelly, 2010). More broadly, consumers may engage in motivated reasoning (Cohen, 2003; Kunda, 1990), construing authenticity in ways that support affiliation over verifiable standards. Taken together, prior work does not definitively establish whether a need for relatedness promotes reliance on fact-based or feeling-based processing. On balance, because a need for relatedness centers on

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intersubjective judgment, we speculate that consumers with a high need for relatedness will generally rely more on fact-based processing, as it is more likely to yield socially shared standards:

> **H11.** Consumers with a high (vs. low) need for relatedness will be more likely to employ the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route when assessing authenticity.

BRAND OUTCOMES

Reliance on fact-based versus feeling-based processing of authenticity has important implications for brand outcomes. Prior research has largely emphasized positive effects of authenticity, such as brand trust and valuation. We extend this work by theorizing how differences in authenticity processing shape both positive and negative outcomes, including consumer loyalty, brand reputational risk, innovation flexibility, and consumer fragmentation.

Consumer loyalty

One key outcome for brands is the degree to which consumers exhibit loyalty due to perceived authenticity. We propose that the more consumers arrive at their authenticity beliefs via the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route, the greater the loyalty the brand will garner. This reasoning mirrors prior work on the ELM, which demonstrates that consumers who engage in central processing of a persuasive message tend to form stronger attitudes than those who rely on peripheral processing (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Consumers relying on the fact-based route prioritize explicit claims (H1a) and diagnostic attributes (H2a). Consequently, they form authenticity assessments that are more epistemically grounded (H3) and characterized by greater social consensus (H4). As a result, brands that achieve authenticity through this route (H1b; H2b) are more likely to gain loyalty from a broader, more predictable segment of the population. Conversely, when consumers rely on the feeling-based route to ascribe authenticity, their judgments are more idiosyncratic (H4), affect-driven, and less elaborated upon as they default to implicit claims (H1a) and superficial attributes (H2a). Thus, such authenticity assessments may produce weaker and less stable positive attitudes, resulting in lower levels of loyalty.

> **H12.** Conditional on authenticity being affirmed, consumers who employ the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will exhibit higher loyalty toward the target brand.

Risk of brand reputational harm

Although consumers using the fact-based route may reward brands with greater loyalty when authenticity is affirmed, they may also impose stronger backlash when authenticity is disconfirmed. Because fact-based processing produces authenticity judgments that are more binary (H5) and epistemically grounded (H3), brands processed via this route may face greater scrutiny. As a result, brands must ensure that the objective quality of their offerings substantiates their explicit claims. If such claims are revealed to be false, brands are more likely to be accused of deception or misrepresentation, leading to heightened reputational costs.

Authenticity judgments formed via the feeling-based route rely more on implicit claims (H1a), which tend to be aesthetic or sensory. The less falsifiable nature of these cues may reduce the likelihood of direct accusations of dishonesty when inconsistencies arise. In this sense, brands processed through the feeling-based route may be buffered from severe backlash. For example, in cases of greenwashing, brands may use sensory cues (e.g., green-colored packaging or nature imagery) to indirectly signal environmental responsibility, regardless of a product's actual environmental impact. Because such cues are less falsifiable (H2a) and result in authenticity judgments that fall on a gradient rather than a binary (H5), consumers relying on the feeling-based route may exhibit weaker punitive responses.

> **H13.** Conditional on authenticity being disconfirmed, consumers who employ the fact-based (vs. feeling-based) route will impose greater backlash on the target brand.

Innovation flexibility

Prior work suggests that one cost of positioning a brand as authentic is increased resistance to product innovation, as changes may be seen as violating authenticity (Han et al., 2021). These effects are especially pronounced for brands whose authenticity is tied to explicit, falsifiable cues, such as claims of consistency over time (e.g., a product has been made the same way for 50 years). When consumers employ the fact-based route to assess authenticity, they are more likely to anchor their judgments in explicit claims (H1a) and diagnostic attributes (H2a). As a result, deviations from these claims, such as updates to longstanding flagship products, may be seen as authenticity violations, leading to greater resistance to innovation. By contrast, authenticity judgments formed via the feeling-based route rely more on implicit claims (H1a). Because such claims are less bound to falsifiable standards, brands processed through this route may face fewer constraints when adapting to trends or introducing innovation.

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H14. Consumers who employ the feeling-based (vs. fact-based) route when assessing authenticity will exhibit greater acceptance of product innovation or change.

Consumer fragmentation

Although innovation and change may be less likely to disrupt authenticity for consumers engaging in feeling-based processing, authenticity judgments formed through this route are also more heterogeneous across individuals. Because authenticity derived from the feeling-based route is more linked to consumers' intuitions and emotions, consumers may rely on cues that lack socially agreed-upon meanings (H4), leading to divergent views of authenticity and consumer fragmentation. Consequently, brands evaluated through the feeling-based route may face greater difficulty forecasting which attributes consumers will perceive as authentic and may need to offer a broader range of products or make more frequent tactical adjustments to accommodate dispersed preferences. For example, a beauty brand that claims its products "make you feel like your true self" may need to provide a wide range of colors and shades or closely track beauty trends to anticipate varied interpretations of authenticity.

H15. Consumers who employ the feeling-based (vs. fact-based) route when assessing authenticity will be less predictable in their judgments and related brand preferences.

Taken together, brands processed through the fact-based route face a higher risk, higher reward dynamic with respect to authenticity. These brands may need to invest more resources to ensure their claims are objectively supported. If they fail to do so, they are likely to face strong consumer backlash (H13). They also may be less able to innovate or deviate far from their authenticity claims (H14). However, if brands fulfill their objective claims, they will likely experience greater rewards in the form of consumer loyalty (H12) as well as stronger consumer consensus and predictability in authenticity perceptions and other claimed attributes (H4; H15).

Brands processed through the feeling-based route may face lower risk but also receive fewer rewards for their authenticity. Because consumers relying on the feeling-based route are less likely to attend to explicit, diagnostic claims, brands are less likely to be accused of inauthenticity and thus are less likely to experience consumer backlash (H13). Relatedly, these brands may require less resources to support their authenticity claims. They also may be more able to nimbly adapt and innovate with trends without risking authenticity (H14). However, because they rely on superficial cues of authenticity, brands are also less likely to gain consumer loyalty (H12) and may struggle to gain consensus across consumers (H4; H15) as they rely on consumers' idiosyncratic and potentially fickle preferences to achieve authenticity, often requiring more diversified offerings to accommodate varied preferences.

CONCLUSION

Authenticity has long been recognized as a highly desired yet elusive property in the marketplace. Consequently, numerous frameworks have emerged documenting its types and components. Rather than further specifying what authenticity is, we shift the focus to how consumers make authenticity judgments. We offer a simplified, integrative framework in which authenticity is the result of a judgment process that proceeds through two distinct routes: a fact-based route and a feeling-based route. By identifying psychological processes as a key source of variation, our framework reconciles longstanding paradoxes in the literature and enables greater conceptual integration by connecting authenticity to well-established theories in consumer behavior and psychology. We also show how this framework predicts the authenticity cues consumers attend to, the characteristics of the judgments, and the moderators that activate these processes. From a managerial perspective, this approach highlights a central strategic question for brands: when consumers evaluate authenticity, will they rely on facts or feelings?

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

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How to cite this article: Smith, R. K., & Du, K. (2026). Authenticity as fact or feeling: A dual-process framework of consumer authenticity judgments. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, *00*, 1–19. https://doi.org/10.1002/jcpy.70030

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